Eunsun Kim

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Education

University of California, Los Angeles, Ph.D. in Quantitative Marketing — Expected 2027

Duke University, M.S. in Economics and Computation — 2021

Seoul National University, M.S. in Quantitative Marketing — 2019

Seoul National University, B.A. in Business — 2017
summa cum laude; Minor in Economics

Research Interests

Quantitative Marketing, Empirical Industrial Organization, AI and Algorithmic Pricing

Job Market Paper

Following to Lead: Dominant Followership in Sequential Price Competition

I study how algorithmic price responses reshape competition when firms differ in demand advantage and response reliability. Using synchronized high-frequency cross-platform pricing data, I find that Amazon, despite being the dominant platform, stands out as an effective follower. I investigate this strategy, which I call dominant followership, as a mechanism through which demand asymmetry can raise prices. A sequential Bertrand model modified to break ties in favor of the dominant firm explains why this mechanism can be incentive-compatible: with a majority of demand at price parity, the dominant firm may prefer to match rather than undercut because matching lets it monetize its existing customer base. Anticipating this response, the rival can profitably initiate price increases that would otherwise be difficult to sustain. Prices rise above the simultaneous-move Nash equilibrium level only when the two asymmetries coincide: the demand-advantaged firm must also be the reliable responder. When pricing is delegated to adaptive algorithms, the same demand and timing asymmetries shape not only current pricing incentives, but also what rivals learn from market feedback over time. In Q-learning simulations, price increases emerge through learning in the rival's algorithm, yet most of the surplus accrues to the dominant firm. The main insight of this paper is that algorithmic price competition among asymmetric firms should be modeled as a sequential response process: when demand asymmetry changes response incentives, individually incentive-compatible pricing decisions can soften competition without explicit coordination.

Working Papers

Can Consumer AI Discipline Algorithmic Pricing?

This project studies whether consumer-side AI shopping agents can weaken dominant-platform pricing power in markets where firms use pricing algorithms. Many consumers begin product search inside a dominant platform and compare only a limited set of alternatives, allowing firms to benefit from search frictions and default position. AI shopping agents can change this environment by searching across platforms, tracking recent price histories, and making price and non-price tradeoffs easier to compare. However, lower search costs need not eliminate platform advantage, because consumers may still value the dominant platform's non-price advantages, such as delivery speed, return convenience, and trust. I model consumer-side AI as lowering search frictions and expanding consumers' consideration sets, which reduces the dominant firm's demand advantage. Starting from a market in which the dominant platform captures a large share of demand, I ask how pricing incentives change as AI agents make consumers more willing to consider rival sellers. The main exercise is a threshold analysis: how much must the dominant firm's demand advantage fall before the dominant-followership mechanism breaks down? I then examine the implications for consumer welfare. The project speaks to a policy question in algorithmic pricing: whether consumer-side AI can discipline dominant platforms through better search, or whether dominant-platform advantages are too persistent for the market to self-correct.

Honors and Research Grants

- AMA-Sheth Consortium Fellow — 2026
- NBER Digital Economics and AI Tutorial — 2025
- Haring Symposium Fellow — 2025
- ISMS Doctoral Consortium Fellow — 2023, 2025
- Price Center for Entrepreneurship and Innovation Research Grant — 2024
- Grand Prize, Mock Fair Trade Commission Contest, Korea Fair Trade Commission — 2017
- Dean's List, Seoul National University Business School — 2015, 2016

Presentations

Following to Lead: Dominant Followership in Sequential Price Competition

- Industrial Organization Proseminar, Department of Economics, UCLA — 2025, 2026
- World Congress of the Econometric Society (ESWC) — 2025
- ISMS Marketing Science Conference — 2025
- Artificial Intelligence in Management (AIM) Conference — 2025

Discussions

- Haring Symposium — 2025
- California Quantitative Marketing Ph.D. Student Conference — 2023, 2024

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, UCLA Anderson School of Management — 2022–present
- Customer Assessment and Analytics (MBA elective), Brett Hollenbeck, Robert Zeithammer
- Data and Decisions (MFE course), H. Tai Lam
- Statistical Foundations for Data Analytics (MSBA course), Peter Rossi

Teaching Assistant, Department of Computer Science, Duke University — 2021
- Everything Data

Graduate Assistant, Center for Data and Visualization Sciences, Duke University — 2020

Teaching Assistant, Seoul National University Business School — 2018–2019
- Data-Driven Marketing Analytics
- Marketing Management

Past Employment

- Mobile Market Research Team, LG Display — 2017
- Intern, Corporate Law Team, Barun Law LLC — 2015

Programming

Python, R, MATLAB, C++, LaTeX

Selected Coursework

University of California, Los Angeles

Theory in Marketing, Robert Zeithammer
Theory of the Firm and Consumer, Ichiro Obara
Game Theory and Information Economics, Moritz Meyer-ter-Vehn
Advanced Econometrics II, Rosa Matzkin
Econometrics III, Rosa Matzkin
Advanced Econometrics III, Denis Chetverikov
Methods Econometrics, Peter Rossi
Econometrics I, Jinyong Hahn
Quantitative Research in Marketing, Brett Hollenbeck and Elisabeth Honka
Industrial Organization, Price Policy, and Regulation, John Asker, Martin Hackmann, and Will Rafey
Applied Analysis of Behavioral Research, Stephen Spiller

Duke University

Computational Microeconomics, Vincent Conitzer
Computer Vision, Carlo Tomasi
Theory and Algorithms for Machine Learning, Cynthia Rudin
Probabilistic Machine Learning, Eric B. Laber
Bayesian and Modern Statistics, Olanrewaju Akande
High-Dimensional Data Analysis, Paul Bendich

Extracurricular

Certified Yoga Instructor, CorePower Yoga

REFERENCES

For letters of recommendation, please contact amy.corrales@anderson.ucla.edu.

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